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in the proverbial beer mug. A group of passionate and enthusiastic beer lovers has set up their own breweries, introducing craft beer to thirsty drinkers. And while this is still a small market (around 2-3 per cent for craft beers), it is growing exponentially. Per the report, the market is forecast to grow at 108 per cent in volume terms.

So, what is craft beer? The Oxford Dictionary (yes, it's in the dictionary) defines it as a beer made in a traditional or non-mechanised way by a small brewery. "It is beer as it was supposed to be, before pasteurisation, chemical stabilisation and artificial flavours," says Manu Gulati, who set up Effingut Breweries in Pune in 2014. "I disliked beer thinking of it as something that bloated you. But that was before I tasted craft beer in the UK. My first reaction was that it was

1 Bira brews its various styles of beer across five breweries in India and is enjoyed in over 500 towns across 15 countries

2 Craft beer is made in a traditional or non-mechanised way by small breweries

'effin' good and that's how Effingut (gut is good in German) was born." Today Effingut has two breweries in Pune, and pubs in Mumbai, Pune, Kolkata and Delhi with 16 variants of beer on tap at each location. It also has growler stations in Mumbai and Pune where you can fill a one litre bottle of beer on tap, consume it at home and then return for a refill. Effingut rotates around six to eight types of beer and Gulati loves to experiment with seasonal ingredients. So, as summer approaches, plans are on to have mango-infused ale

and kokum-infused beer. A couple of years ago he introduced Effingud (gud as in jaggery) as the beer had jaggery, an ode to Lohri as the beer was introduced around that time. "In the last nine years we have introduced around 300 different variations," says Gulati, adding that Indians love sweet beer and wheat beer is the most popular. However, palates are developing, he says. Eight years ago, when he launched the IPA or the Indian Pale Ale at the Pune pub, he sold 500 litres in six months; now he sells a 1,000 litres a week. Gulati says the market is growing with more players coming in. He was only the second craft brewer in Maharashtra. Today there are 19.

Of course, no conversation about craft beer can happen without mentioning Bira 91, which introduced us to craft beer in bottles and cans. Bira 91 was established a year after